

[https://www.somdnews.com/independent/news/local/sisters-reminisce-prepare-for-church-dinner-in-accokeek/article\\_f3d035ef-fbe0-4acd-8fff-5e01abcd737d.html](https://www.somdnews.com/independent/news/local/sisters-reminisce-prepare-for-church-dinner-in-accokeek/article_f3d035ef-fbe0-4acd-8fff-5e01abcd737d.html)

CENTERPIECE

## Sisters reminisce, prepare for church dinner in Accokeek

Ilana Williams [iwilliams@somdnews.com](mailto:iwilliams@somdnews.com)

Nov 12, 2025

1 of 3



The Rev. Brian Vander Wel, left, 43rd rector of the Christ Church Accokeek, stands with Dorothy Showalter and church. They are preparing for the church's 100th annual ham and oyster dinner on Nov. 22.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

There is a tradition of many churches in Southern Maryland that offer church dinners for fundraisers and to support one another.

Sometimes they serve chicken. Other times it's crabs or fish.

At Christ Church Accokeek it's one dozen fried oysters and all-you-can-eat ham with turnips, potato salad, green beans, apple sauce and rolls. And that's a tradition that's gone on for a century.

Christ Church is holding its 100th annual Ham and Oyster Dinner on Saturday, Nov. 22, from noon to 6 p.m. Adults pay \$30 and children 5 to 12 pay \$15; kids four and under eat free.

Over the last century, the way oysters were served has changed, Elizabeth "Betty" Dillon, a member of the church, said. They had raw oysters, oyster stew and fried oysters.

"I didn't think ... when I went to other dinners, I was supporting them," Dillon, 94, said. "I just want to eat their dinners because ham and oysters [are] delicious."

The dinner also offers a buttercream candy and bake sale and a twice-new sale, which is like a flea market, that opens at 10 a.m.

The dinners were for financial need, but it's also tradition and to continue the mission of the church, which is to lead people to new life and growing discipleship,

The Rev. Brian Vander Wel, who is the 43rd rector of the Christ Church Accokeek, said last year the church served around 400 dinners. They offer dine-in and carry-out dinners.

"They come and eat dinner here and they like it so much they go to carry out when they leave so they can get another dinner when they take it home," Vander Wel, who will be attending his 19th dinner this year, said.

---

The church's goal this year is to serve 600 people, he said. They are getting 90 gallons of oysters.

"My earliest days they shucked the oysters," Barbara Sturman, Dillon's daughter, said. "Then we started buying them in gallon buckets."

Dillon and her sister Dorothy Showalter used to carry water from the spring to make tea and coffee and to wash the dishes, Dillon said.

"Not that many people were around then," Showalter, 96, said. "Now they come quite a distance."

Christ Church is a traditional and small church, but it's not all "old and gray," Vander Wel said, adding that younger kids help with the dinner and service that gives it a "youthful energy."

The Sunday before the dinner people make candy after church services, Dillion said.

People in the church used to pick kale to be washed and cooked, Dillon said. Now they cook green beans and mashed turnips.

"It's interesting how the dinner does change each year," Vander Wel said.



#### **Getting set in the kitchen**

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News Nov 10, 2025